Background Guide for the United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (CSW)

Committee Overview and Mandate

The Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) is the principal global intergovernmental body exclusively dedicated to the promotion of gender equality and the empowerment of women. A functional commission of the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), it was established by Economic and Social Council Resolution 11(II) of 21 June 1946.

The CSW is instrumental in promoting women's rights; providing statistical information about women's employment, access to healthcare and education, and standards of living; and shaping global standards on gender equality and the empowerment of women. In 1996, ECOSOC's Resolution 1996/6 expanded the Commission's mandate and decided that it should take a leading role in monitoring and reviewing progress and problems in the implementation of the 1995 *Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action*, and in mainstreaming a gender perspective in UN activities.

Following the 2015 adoption of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, the Commission was mandated to contribute to the follow-up to the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, with a particular focus on accelerating the realization of gender equality and the empowerment of women (ECOSOC *Resolution 2015/6*)." [1]

A primary focus of the CSW in 2022 is the economic empowerment of women in a changing world of work. The CSW aims to address challenges women face when trying to enter the workforce, as well as inequalities that arise within the workforce. Additionally, it addresses how changes to the modern economy will affect women and how to combat gender discrimination which can arise from this modernization. UN-Women supports all aspects of the CSW's work.

Women's Economic Empowerment in a Changing World of Work

Discrimination

Women's role in many societies as the primary caregiver is one of the main causes of limited employment opportunities.[2] Women are often expected to take care of domestic chores and childcare, which makes it difficult to seek work opportunities outside of the home or to balance

[1] http://www.unwomen.org/en/csw
[2] UN-Women, Millennium Development Goals: Gender Chart, 2014, p. 2.

work responsibilities with other obligations.[3] The jobs that women tend to fulfill are often lower-level, unskilled jobs that do not provide healthcare benefits or maternity leave, or that fall into the category of the "informal sector."[4] Given overwhelming evidence that expanding women's employment options and opportunities contributes to increased economic growth, it is critical that the international community tackle this issue.[5] A decrease in the gap between women's and men's labor force participation results in faster economic growth.[6] A developing country that is doing very well in this regard is Rwanda, ranking 6th in the *2015 Global Gender Gap Index.* Both at an international and domestic level conventions and laws have been created to prevent discrimination against women. For example, the *Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Discrimination Against Women* (CEDAW) of 1979 focused on equal opportunity for women in all aspects.[7] However, slow progress on the issue indicates that international treaties are not being enforced, while many judicial systems are ineffective.[8] In addition, certain Member States lack necessary legislation empowering and protecting women in the workplace, enabling discrimination against women to continue.[9] In a study including 143 states, almost 90% had at least some regulations in their legal system that restricted economic opportunities for women.[10] In some cases, husbands can regulate or prevent women from joining the job force.[11]

At a global level, women are paid less than men, earning on average approximately 60 to 75% of men's wages.[12] This not only has an effect on women's present life circumstances, but also has long-term consequences for individual and family savings, social security, and retirement.[13] Not being allowed to work is not the only discrimination women face in the economy; while in the work force women often are only able to get low-income jobs or underpaid jobs.[14] Some of these jobs include childcare, housekeeping, and cooking.[15] Most of these jobs do not provide medical insurance, retirement funds, or maternity leave.[16]

Education

Increasing education for women and girls has proven to have beneficial economic outcomes. Efforts by Member States in the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) to increase educational opportunities for women and girls account for approximately 50%

---

[3] Ibid.
[4] ILO, Women at Work, Trends 2016, 2016, p. 41.
[5] OECD, Gender Equality in Education, Employment and Entrepreneurship: Final Report to the MCM, 2012.
[6] Ibid.
[7] UN General Assembly, Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (A/RES/34/180), 1979.
[8] ILO, Women at Work, Trends 2016, 2016, p. 69.
[9] World Bank, Women, Business and Law 2014: Removing Restrictions to Enhance Gender Equality, 2014, p. 8.
[10] Ibid.
[11] Ibid.
[12] World Bank, Gender Data Portal, 2016.
[13] Mlambo-Ngcuka, Equal Pay Matters, 2016.
[14] Ibid.
[15] Ibid.
[16] ILO, Women at Work, Trends 2016, 2016, p. 81.

of recent economic growth.[17] Increased access to higher education for girls is a substantial part of this growth; education plays a key role in the types of jobs women are able to hold.. Though women increasingly have pursued higher education opportunities—in many developed Member States they represent a majority of university graduates—the Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math (STEM) fields continue to be dominated by men, foreclosing women's access to some of the highest paying jobs. There have been efforts to better equip women studying and working in STEM through targeted programs, but many Member States lack the resources to offer such opportunities.[18]

CSW and UN-Women work closely with UNICEF, which looks to make sure that girls are not held back from attending school by promoting a multifaceted approach both to ensuring girls go to school and that they stay in school. The high dropout rate among girls is a continuing problem,[19] yet empowering women and girls through education is vital to achieving the 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda[20]. Mainstreaming gender equality can encourage sustainable development within the education sector,[21] which can be achieved through the work of civil society, development agencies, Member States, multilateral institutions such as the World Bank and the UN Development Programme, and the private sector[22]. In line with SDG 4, ensuring quality education, UNESCO, the UN Population Fund (UNFPA), and UN-Women have partnered on a number of projects to empower girls through education[23]. In order to help Member States achieve gender equality in education, the United Nations Girls' Education Initiative (UNGEI) puts the rights of girls first, supports life skills-based education, and promotes female role models in education[24]. To further promote gender equality, States can implement UNICEF's Child Friendly Schools to provide a gender-sensitive environment that is conducive to learning at all levels[25].

An example of a private sector initiative for women's economic empowerment is Walmart's *Global Women's Economic Empowerment Initiative* that has trained nearly 1 million women for various professional positions and provides job training, education, mentoring, and career counseling.[26]

---

[17] OECD, Gender Equality in Education, Employment and Entrepreneurship: Final Report to the MCM 2012, p. 3.
[18] ILO, Women at Work, Trends 2016, 2016, p. 92.
[19] UN DSPD, Youth and Education, p. 1.

[20] UN General Assembly, Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1), 2015

[21] UN General Assembly, Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1), 2015

[22] UNESCO, Education for All Movement

[23] UNESCO, Three UN agencies join forces to boost education for girls and young women. http://en.unesco.org/news/three-agencies-join-forces-boost-education-adolescent-girls-and-young-women

[24] UNICEF, Girls' Education and Gender Equality https://www.unicef.org/education/bege_70640.html

[25] UNICEF, Child Friendly Schools https://www.unicef.org/cfs/

[26] Walmart, Walmart's Global Women's Economic Empowerment Initiative

Technology Access

Information and communication technologies (ICTs) play a major role in the changing world of work. The Digital Revolution has made full Internet access a necessity for a competitive economy. ICT access is the focus of Sustainable Development Goal 9 and of many UN-related efforts. While 95% of the global population lives in an area that is covered by a mobile-cellular network, and nearly 50% of the global population had access to the Internet in 2016, developing Member States have significantly lower rates of utilization.[27] Ensuring ICT access in developing countries is crucial in the development of competitive economies. The greatest barriers to ICT access are a lack of ICT infrastructure, and a lack of funding for ICT access in developing countries.

Since ICT access is playing such a major role in the changing world of work, it is crucial that women receive equal access to ICTs; the continuing gender-based "digital divide" represents a significant obstacle to women having access to diverse and meaningful employment opportunities. ICT access rates by women are lower than the access rates of men in all regions of the world. While in developed countries the gap is approximately 2.3%, in developing Member States the gap is 7.6%; the figures for Least Developed Member States are significantly higher.[28] While the gender gap in ICT access is lower in developed countries, there are no regions in which this gap does not exist. Organizations in addition to the CSW and UN-Women also work to address the gender digital divide, including the Association for Progressive Communication Women's *Networking Support Programme* (APCWNSP). The APCWNSP focuses on women's empowerment through promoting women's utilization of ICTs around the world.

Conclusion

Delegates should focus their research on these three subsections: discrimination, education, and technology access. By addressing the issues which can lead to women being unable to obtain employment or equal employment opportunities, and the changes happening to the modern economy, delegates will be able to create comprehensive resolutions for the Commission on the Status of Women.

<u>Questions to Consider</u>

What obstacles do women currently face in obtaining employment?

What inequalities exist for women in the work place?

[27] The World Bank, Information and Communications Technologies Overview
[28] ICT Facts and Figures 2016, ITU Telecommunication Development Bureau.

What jobs are women more likely to hold in developing Member States?

What has the UN done to enhance employment opportunities for women?

What role does education play in the economy?

What has the UN done concerning education for girls and women?

What has been done to increase female involvement in STEM fields?

What is meant by the changing world of work, and what role does the digital revolution play?

What can be done to expand ICT access, particularly for women?

Bibliography

United Nations Statistics Division & United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women. (2014). Millennium Development Goals: Gender Chart [Report]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://www.unwomen.org/~/media/7107C11333C046D8BBD0BE6BA5FD251A.ashx

International Labour Organization. (2016). Women at Work, Trends 2016 [Report]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://www.ilo.org/wcmsp5/groups/public/---reports/---dcomm/--publ/documents/publication/wcms_457317.pdf

Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (2012). Gender Equality in Education, Employment and Entrepreneurship: Final Report to the MCM [Report]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://www.oecd.org/employment/50423364.pdf

United Nations, General Assembly, Thirty-fourth session. (1979). Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (A/RES/34/180). Adopted on the report of the Third Committee (A/34/830). Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://undocs.org/A/RES/34/180

World Bank. (2016). Women, Business and Law 2016 [Report]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://wbl.worldbank.org/~/media/WBG/WBL/Documents/Reports/2016/Women-Business-and-the-Law-2016.pdf

World Bank. (2016). Gender Data Portal [Report]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://datatopics.worldbank.org/gender/

United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women. (2016). Planet 50-50 by 2030: Step It Up for Gender Equality [Website]. Retrieved 4 May 2017 from: http://www.unwomen.org/en/getinvolved/step-it-up

World Bank. (2016). Information and Communications Overview. [Website]. Retrieved 28 April 2017 from: http://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/ict/overview

ITU Telecommunications Development Bureau. (2016). ICT Facts and Figures 2016. [Website]. Retrieved 28 April 2017 from: http://www.itu.int/en/ITU-D/Statistics/Documents/facts/ICTFactsFigures2016.pdf

ILO. 2016. Women at Work, Trends 2016. 25 Apr 2017. Q http://www.ilo.org/wcmsp5/groups/public/---dgreports/---dcomm/---publ/documents/publication/wcms_457317.pdf

OECD. 2012. Gender Equality in Education, Employment and Entrepreneurship: Final Report to the MCM. 24 Apr 2017. https://www.oecd.org/employment/50423364.pdf

UNESCO. 2016. Girls' and Womens' Literacy with a lifelong learning perspective: issues, trends and implications for the sustainable development goals. 24 Apr 2017. http://unesdoc.unesco.org/images/0024/002449/244959e.pdf

UN-Women. 2015. Progress of the World's Women 2015-2016. 24 Apr 2017. http://progress.unwomen.org/en/2015/pdf/UNW_progressreport.pdf

Walmart. 2011. Walmart Launches Global Women's Economic Empowerment Initiative. 24 Apr 2017. http://corporate.walmart.com/_news_/news-archive/2011/09/14/walmart-launches-global-womens-economic-empowerment-initiative

Programs and Helpful Links for Research

http://weprinciples.org/Site/PrincipleOverview/

http://www.heforshe.org/~/media/HeForShe/Files/impactchampion/HeForShe_IMPACT10X10X10_Brief.pdf

http://skillsforchange.org/women/

http://unesdoc.unesco.org/images/0024/002449/244959e.pdf

http://corporate.walmart.com/_news_/news-archive/2011/09/14/walmart-launches-global-womens-economic-empowerment-initiative

https://www.oecd.org/employment/50423364.pdf

http://www.ilo.org/wcmsp5/groups/public/---dgreports/---dcomm/---publ/documents/publication/wcms_457317.pdf

http://progress.unwomen.org/en/2015/pdf/UNW_progressreport.pdf

http://www.apc.org/en/about/programmes/womens-networking-support-programme-apc-wnsp

http://www.ictforwoman.gov.eg/pub_stud.aspx

http://www.un.org/womenwatch/ianwge/activities/Questionnaires.PDF

Regional Organizations

African Union-

https://www.au.int/

Arab League-

http://www.arableagueonline.org/

Association of South East Asian Nations-

http://asean.org/

Asian Cooperation Dialogue-

http://www.acd-dialogue.org/

European Union-

https://europa.eu/european-union/index_en

Economic Community of West African States-

http://www.ecowas.int/

Organization of American States-

http://www.oas.org/en/

Pacific Islands Forum-

http://www.forumsec.org/

Union of South American Nations-

http://www.unasur.int/en

International Agencies

Europol-

https://www.europol.europa.eu/

International Police Association-

http://www.ipa-iac.org/

INTERPOL-

https://www.interpol.int/

International Criminal Court-

https://www.icc-cpi.int/

United Nations Entities

International Peace and Security-

http://www.un.org/en/sections/priorities/international-peace-and-security/

Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs

http://www.unocha.org/

United Nations Assistance Mission to Iraq-

http://www.uniraq.org/index.php?lang=en

United Nations Charter-

http://www.un.org/en/charter-united-nations/

United Nations Country Team Iraq-

http://www.uniraq.com/index.php?option=com_k2&view=item&layout=item&id=944&Itemid=479&lang=en

United Nations Developmental Assistance Framework-

https://www.un.org/ecosoc/sites/www.un.org.ecosoc/files/files/en/qcpr/doco-summary-brief-on-undaf-march2016.pdf

United Nations Department of Peacekeeping Operations-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/about/dpko/

United Nations Department of Political Affairs-

http://www.un.org/undpa/en

United Nations Development Programme in Nigeria-

http://www.ng.undp.org/

United Nations Office of the Special Advisor on Africa

http://www.un.org/en/africa/osaa/

United Nations Peacekeeping-

http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/

United Nations Security Council-

http://www.un.org/en/sc/

United Nations Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee-

https://www.un.org/sc/ctc/

United Nations Security Council Documents-

http://www.un.org/en/sc/documents/

United Nations Supervision Mission in Syria-

http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/missions/unsmis/